



Chartres Cathedral

The best-preserved example of Gothic architecture in France, renowned for its Chartres blue stained glass

French Gothic architecture reached its most coherent expression in Chartres Cathedral. Many medieval cathedrals took decades or even centuries to build, resulting in a patchwork of architectural styles, but not Chartres. When the town's old Romanesque cathedral burned down in 1194, the local community pulled together to complete a new cathedral in just 26 years. Consequently, the new cathedral was wholly Gothic: cruciform in shape with two towers on the west facade, a curved apse and radiating chapels, and filled with height and light. Its vault rises 112 ft (34 m) above the nave floor; its walls are largely composed of stained glass.

Original features

Few medieval buildings have remained as untouched as Chartres Cathedral. Much of its 32,000 square ft (3,000 square m) of stained glass dates from the early 13th century, as do the narrative sculptures around the cathedral's portals and a tiled labyrinth that leads pilgrims around the floor of the nave.



▷ ASYMMETRICAL FACADE

The symmetry of Chartres' west end is broken by its mismatched towers; the original Gothic north tower (left) fell in 1506 and was replaced with a tower in the late Gothic Flamboyant style.

◁ ROYAL PORTAL

The carved figures on the jambs of Chartres' west, or royal, portal date from the mid-12th century and are thought to depict royal ancestors of Christ from the Old Testament.

FLYING BUTTRESSES

Typical of Gothic cathedrals, the flying buttresses at Chartres Cathedral work by transferring the weight of the roof, or vault, via a series of half arches that "fly" from the upper part of a wall to a buttress some distance away. The innovation allowed medieval cathedral builders to build higher than before using thinner columns and walls with large apertures for stained-glass windows, dramatically opening up the interior space and flooding it with light.

